A Moment Beside the River

Cool air flowed around me as our train moved along the edge of a mountain. Last year, my family and I traveled to Alaska on a cruise, and during our visit to Skagway, we took a train through the woods. Below me, green trees covered the slopes, stretching down farther than I could see. The sky was bright, and the air carried the earthy smell of mud and wood. All of a sudden, a river appeared through the trees. Pale water rushed between large gray rocks, breaking into white swirls around them. My attention followed the water through the forest. I could feel the cold air against me while looking at the thick greenery below. Although I was riding on a train, I felt surrounded by the woods, as if I were moving through nature rather than watching it from a distance.

What astonished me was the difference between the rushing water and the trees beside it. The river looked powerful enough to sweep away anything in its path, yet the trees stood steadily along its banks. Their leaves were still green, with no yellow that I could see. In such a cold place, that greenness surprised me. The trees seemed untouched by the force passing right beside them. Looking back, I realize that their stillness did not mean they were separate from the river. They shared the same place, even though they seemed to move at completely different speeds. This was what made nature feel majestic to me: its power and its calm could exist together. I felt small beside that landscape, but I also felt that I belonged in it.

Looking at the trees now, I see the person I want to become. They stood straight beside the rushing water, like people who refuse to back down or fall, no matter how hard life hits them. The current becomes an image of the challenges I cannot always control, while the trees suggest the strength to face them without losing myself. Their roots are hidden in the photograph, but I imagine them as the beliefs that keep a person steady. This connects to Emerson's idea of self-reliance, which emphasizes trusting one's own judgment rather than surrendering it to pressure from others. Being strong does not mean that nothing

can affect me. It means that even when I feel pressure, I can return to what I believe and decide how to respond. The trees also help me understand individualism: I can belong to the world around me while keeping my own sense of who I am. Finding this meaning in the scene is itself an act of self-trust, because it comes from my own attention and reflection.

The air flowing around me also helps me understand the transcendentalist idea of the Over-Soul, a spiritual unity connecting people and the natural world. The woods reached me through more than sight. I could smell the earth and wood and feel the air moving against me. That physical connection helps explain why I felt part of the landscape instead of simply looking at it. I cannot claim that one train ride proved a spiritual belief, but it made the feeling behind that belief easier to understand. Being a small part of nature did not make the experience less personal; it gave my own awareness somewhere larger to belong. Now, when I look at the photograph, I notice how much it cannot hold. The river is frozen in place, and the air is missing. Remembering those things reminds me to give the world my attention while I am actually in it.